

HERO Software — GTM Funnel Analysis

15-Minute Presentation | Senior GTM Analyst Case Study

Opening: The Truth (1 min)

"Sales blames lead quality. Marketing says Sales isn't converting. We need to know the truth."

Both sides are right — about different segments.

- Sales is correct that PV leads are unworkable (1.6% booking rate, 40% connect rate). Wrong to generalise it to all leads.
- Marketing is correct that core-trade leads can be converted (SHK + Elektro at 21%+). Wrong to call it a Sales execution failure — SDRs already deprioritise PV on purpose (1.75 calls vs 4.25 for SHK).

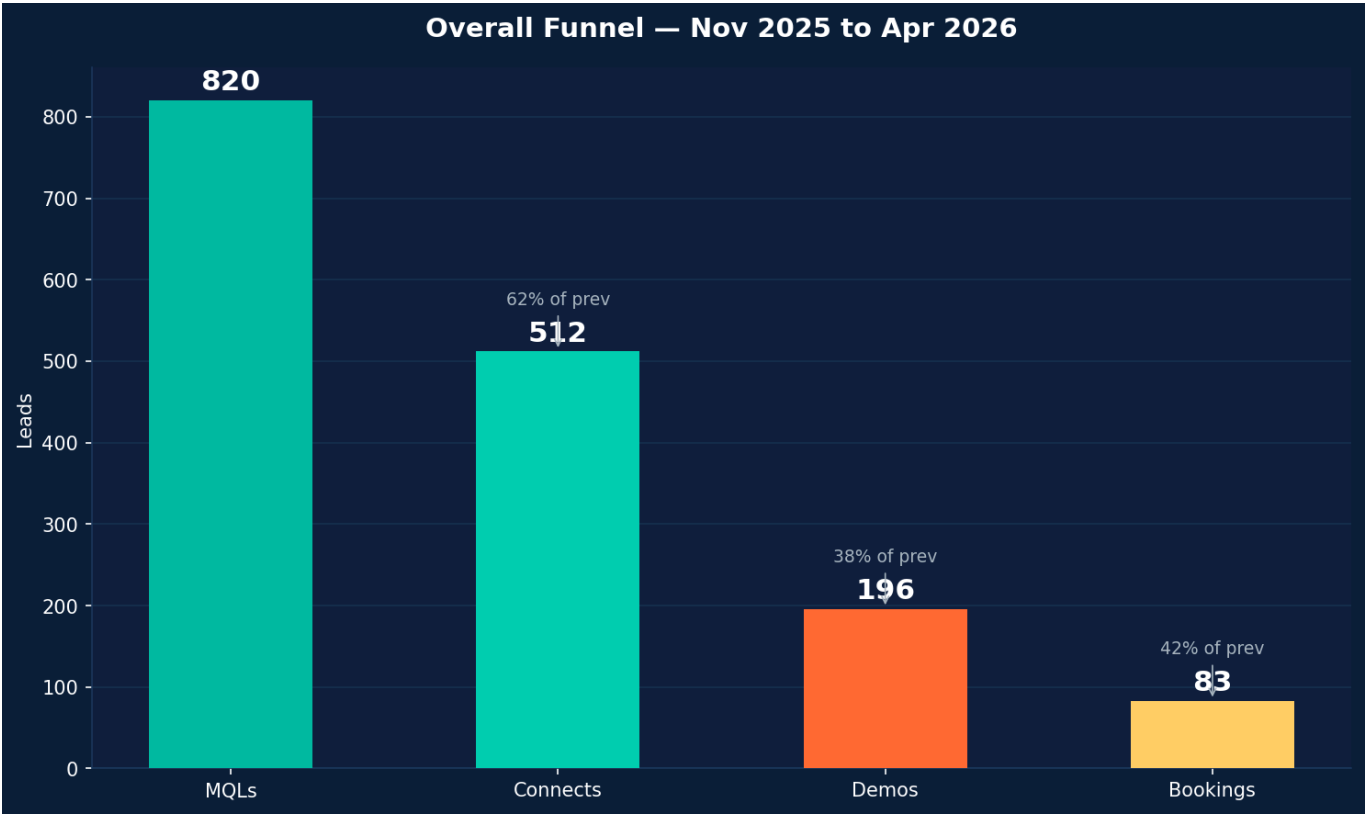
The truth: Neither team is the problem. Marketing scaled PV without updating the ICP — and no feedback loop existed to catch it.

Task 1 — Diagnose the Funnel

Where exactly does the funnel break?

Overall funnel (820 leads, Nov 2025 – Apr 2026):

Stage	Count	Step Conv.
MQLs	820	—
Connects	512	62.4%
Demos	196	38.3%
Bookings	83	10.1%

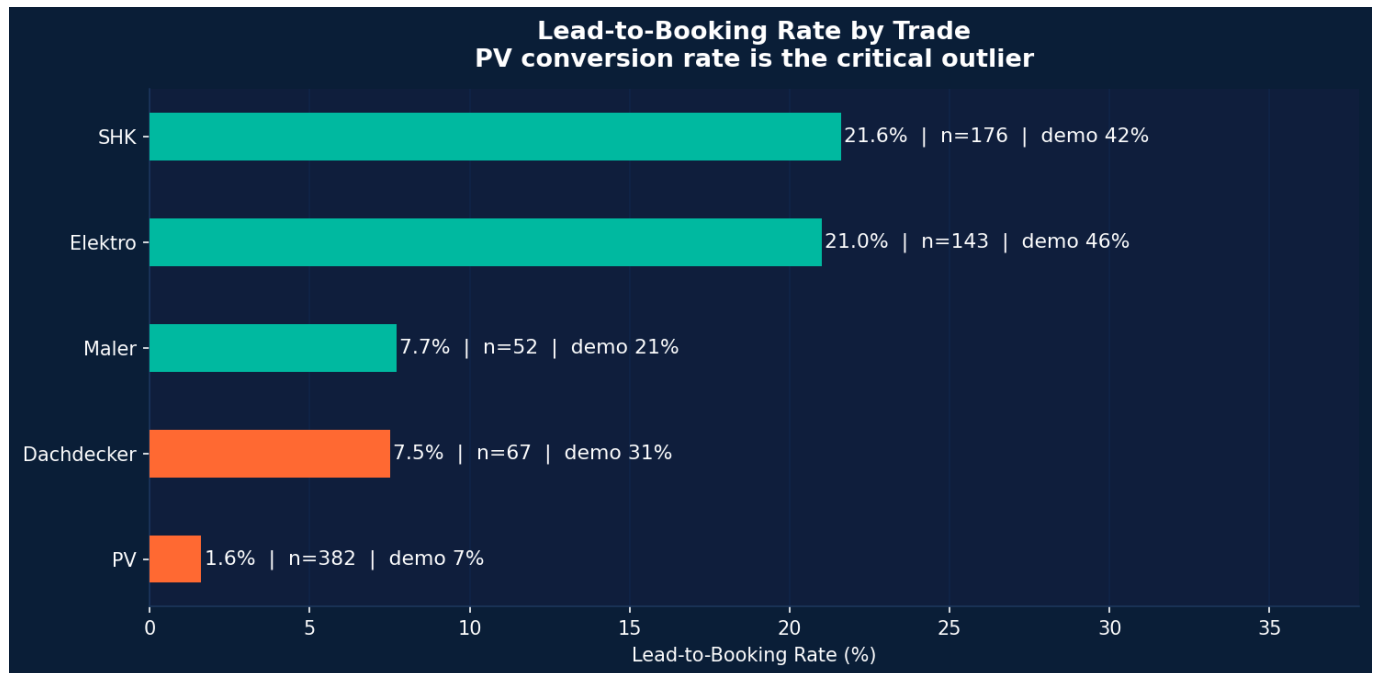


Two leakage points: **MQL** → **Connect** (37.6% never pick up) and **Connect** → **Demo** (only 38% reach a demo). Demo → Booking at 42% is healthy — the product closes well when the right person sees it.

But the break is not uniform. Cut by trade and the picture is stark:

Trade	MQLs	Connect %	Demo %	Booking %
SHK	176	85%	42%	21.6%
Elektro	143	85%	46%	21.0%
PV	382	40%	7%	1.6%

The funnel breaks almost entirely **at the top, inside the PV segment**. PV leads don't pick up (low connect), don't demo (low intent), and rarely buy. The rest of the funnel is performing well.



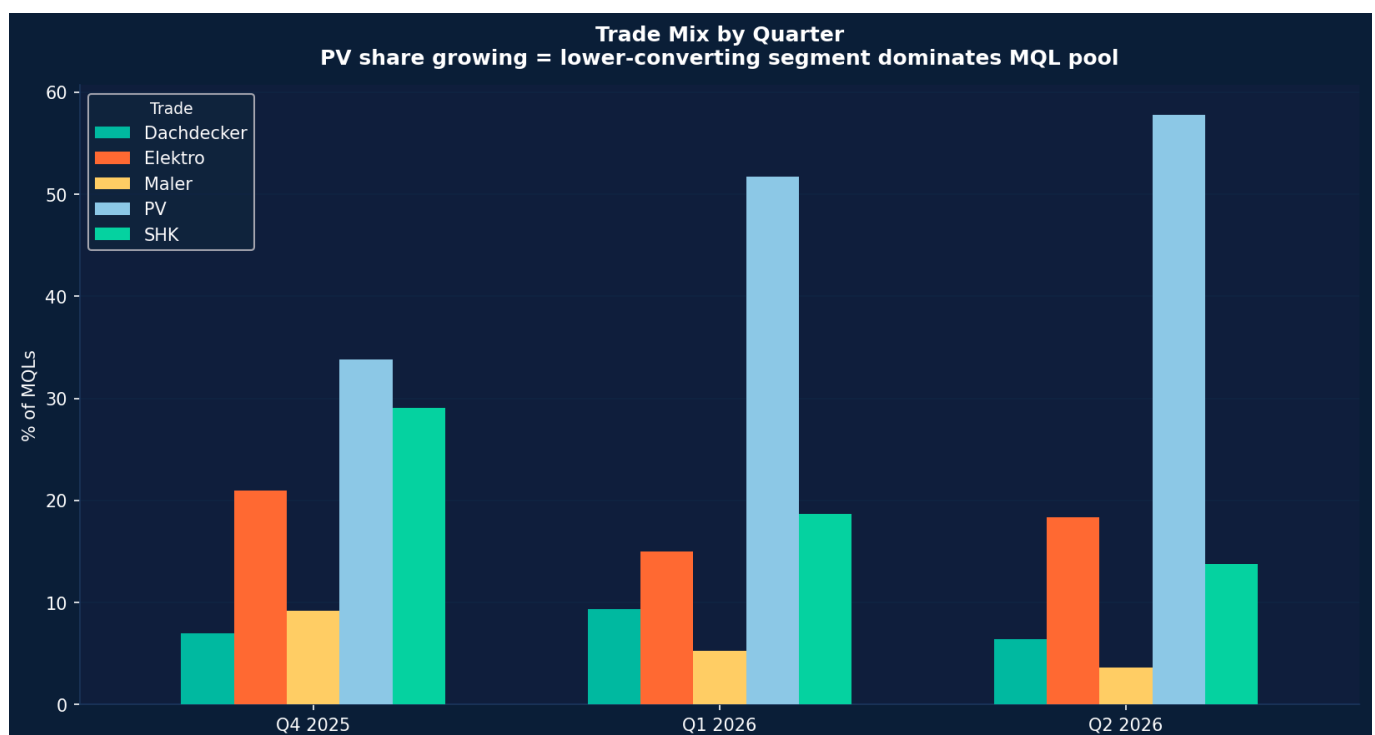
What are the 2–3 most likely root causes?

H1 — PV ICP Mismatch (Primary)

Marketing scaled a segment the product isn't ready to win yet.

Evidence:

- PV grew from **34%** → **58%** of MQLs between Q4 2025 and Q2 2026
- As PV share rose, overall booking rate fell from **11.4%** → **6.4%** — arithmetic, not coincidence



- Transcripts confirm why: PV leads are too early-stage ("we just started doing PV"), too small (1–2 person shops), or confused about the product ("I thought this was for SHK")

- Lead score didn't catch it — median score flat at 56–57 across all quarters despite PV flooding the pool

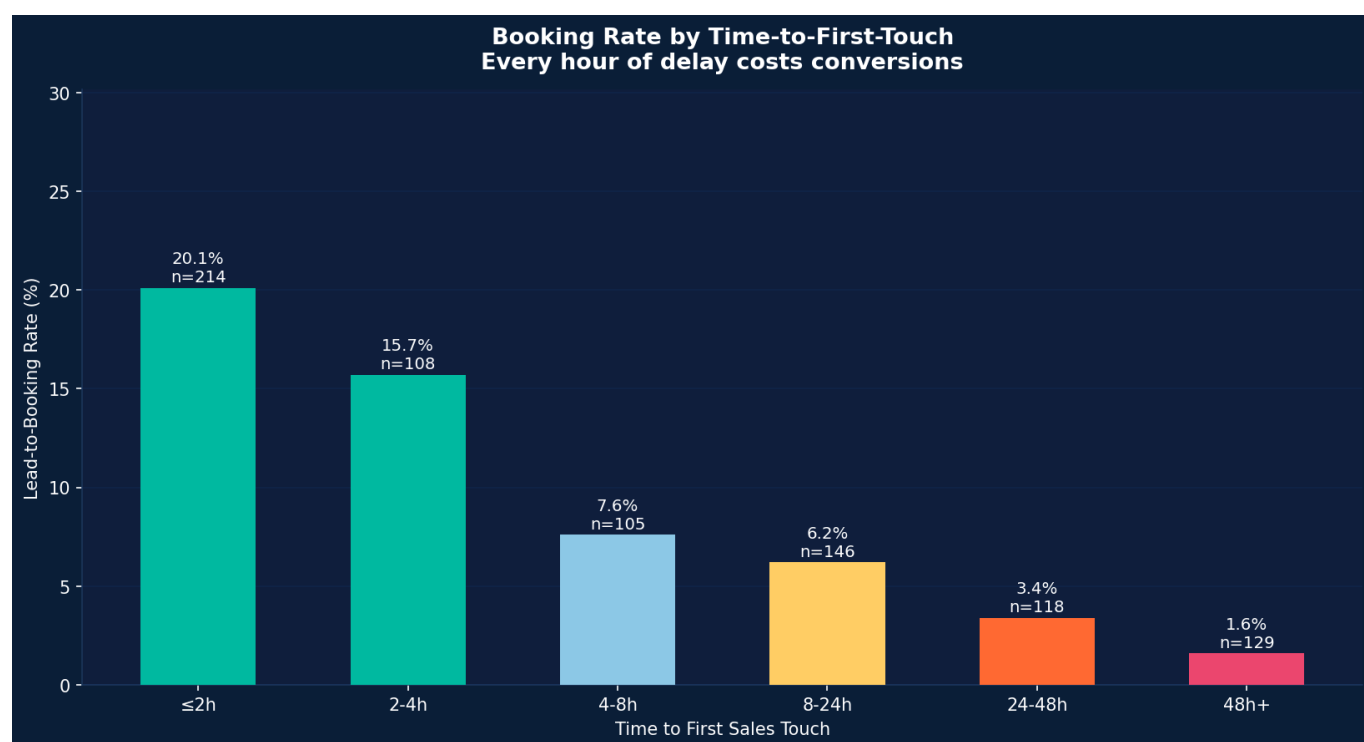
Strength: High. The smoking gun.

H2 — Response-Time Gap on Core Trades (Compounding)

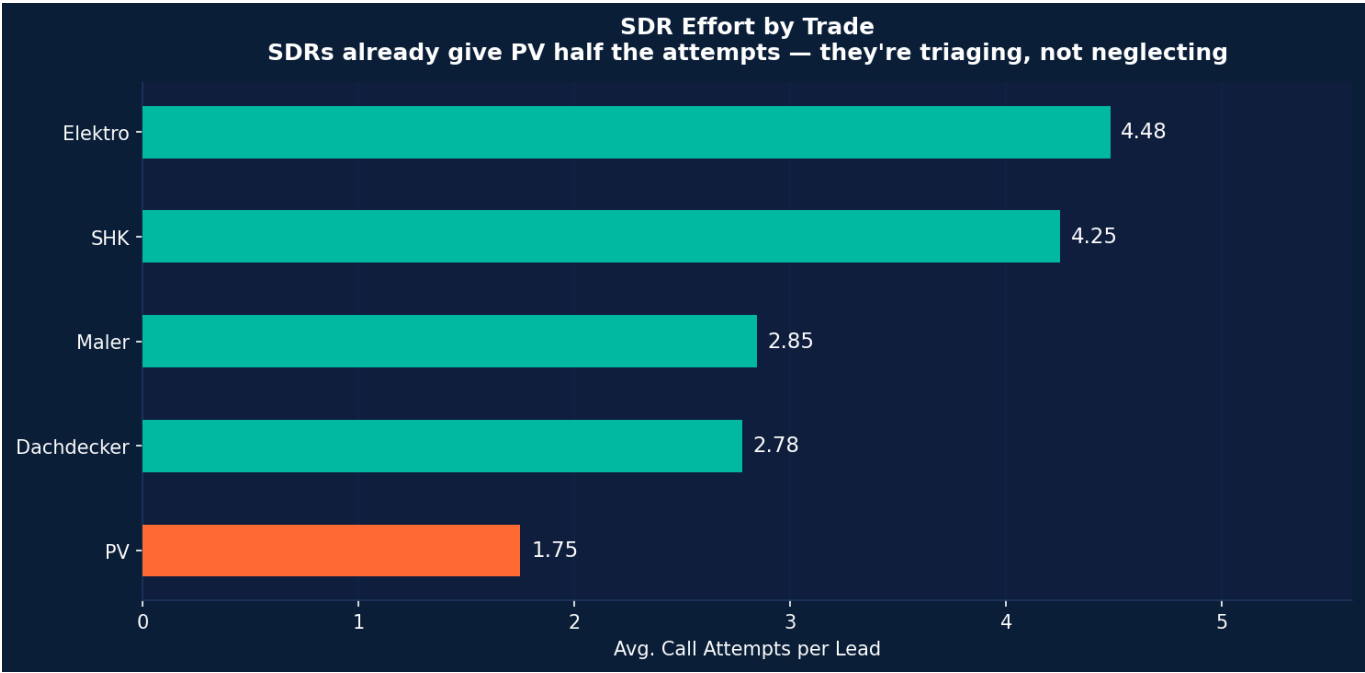
Fast follow-up on good leads is being missed.

Within SHK + Elektro only:

Touch Speed	Booking Rate
≤ 2 hours	28.8%
> 24 hours	4.5%



Caveat: 80% of slow-touched leads are PV — SDRs aren't neglecting good leads, they're correctly triaging bad ones. The response-time lever applies to **core-trade leads only**, where the recoverable ARR is ~€38k.



Strength: Moderate. Real for core trades, but not the headline number.

H3 — Demo Quality Degradation (Secondary)

Wrong leads reaching demo stage waste AE time.

- Q2 2026 demo-to-booking rate dropped to **30%** vs 41% in Q4 2025
- 1–2 MA segment reaches demos at 14% rate but closes at only 4.5% — unqualified leads slipping through

Strength: Moderate. Real but secondary — tackle after H1.

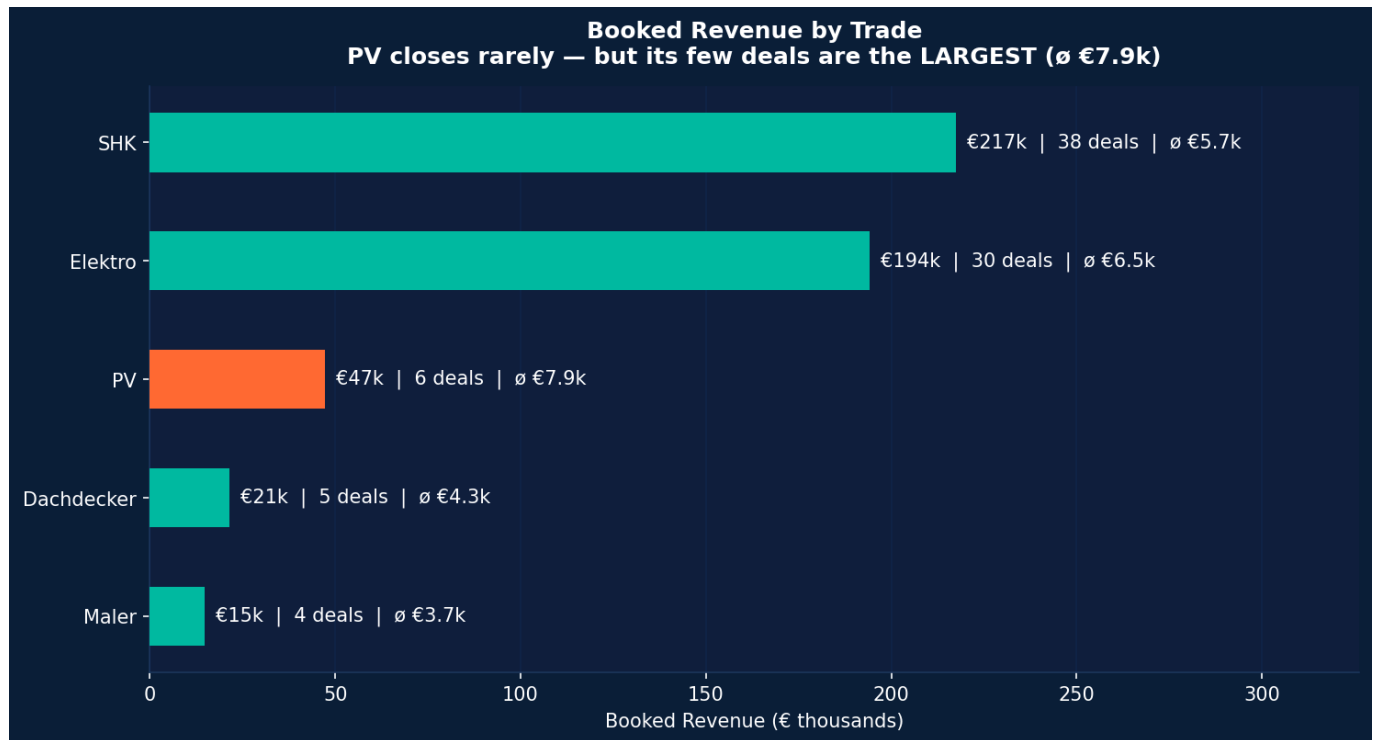
Which hypothesis first? (Impact × Feasibility)

Hypothesis	Revenue Impact	Effort	Speed
H1: PV ICP filter	Very High — fixes 47% of MQL pool	Medium	4–6 weeks
H2: Core-trade SLA	Low–Moderate (~€38k)	Low	1–2 weeks
H3: Demo gates	Medium	Low	2–3 weeks

H1 first — it's the lever. The entire funnel degradation traces back to PV dilution. Everything else is noise by comparison.

H2 in parallel — a 2-week quick win that builds credibility without waiting for H1 to land. Don't oversell the revenue impact.

Important nuance: PV is not worthless — its deals are the **largest of any trade (ø €7,857)**. The fix is to gate *early-stage / sub-scale* PV, not abandon the segment.



Task 2 — The Creative Lever

The problem with the current state

20 call transcripts are filed and forgotten. They contain exact customer language, objection patterns, competitive intelligence, and ICP signals — none of which feed back into Marketing targeting, lead scoring, or Sales playbooks.

The framework: Disqualification Intelligence Loop

Conceptual sketch — three steps:

Step 1 — Tag every DQ call (30 seconds in CRM):

- **dq_category**: Timing | Wrong-Fit | Competitor | Price | Product Gap | Process
- **objection_verbatim**: one sentence in the customer's words
- **urgency_horizon**: now | 3–6 months | 12 months+ | never

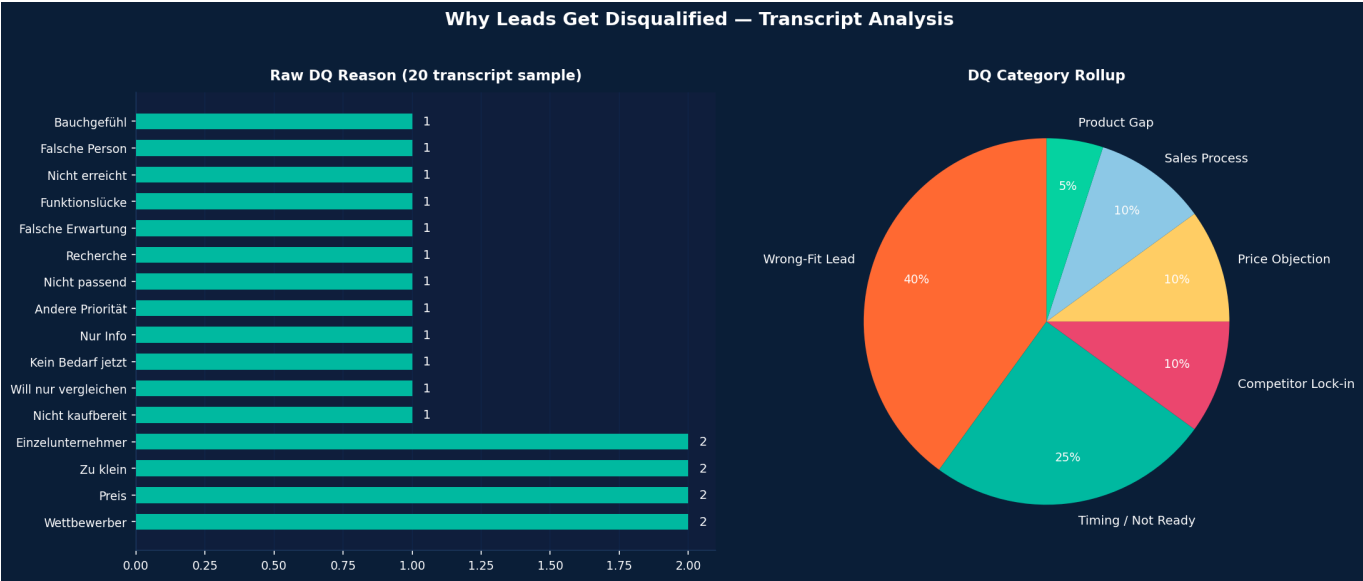
Step 2 — Weekly DQ digest (auto-built from CRM tags):

- DQ breakdown by source → Marketing sees which channels bring wrong-fit leads
- DQ breakdown by trade → surfaces product-market fit gaps per segment
- Trending objections week-over-week → early warning for market shifts

Step 3 — Close the loop:

- Marketing: adjust creative/targeting based on DQ patterns
- Sales: update qualification scripts with disqualifying questions
- RevOps: feed DQ signals into lead score as negative inputs

Scale path: Manual CRM tags (Week 1) → keyword classifier on call notes (Month 2) → LLM tagger auto-feeding lead score (Month 3)



Concrete Output 1 — For Marketing: Source Contamination Map

Source	Primary DQ Pattern	Implication	Action
Meta Ads	"Nur Info" / "Falsche Erwartung" — product confusion	Meta attracts curiosity, not intent	Show product UI in ads; add "for teams of 5+" in copy
Google Ads	"Kein Bedarf jetzt" / "Will nur vergleichen"	Keywords too broad	Add negative keywords: "Was ist", "kostenlos"; create comparison pages
Organic	"Wettbewerber" — PlanCraft, streit.net	Reaches later-stage evaluators already locked in	Build "PlanCraft Alternative" landing pages

Why this goes beyond the obvious: Instead of using transcripts to coach reps on objection handling (the standard play), this routes the signal *upstream* to Marketing — changing who enters the funnel before Sales ever sees them.

Concrete Output 2 — For Sales: Early-Kill Qualification Script

Built from actual transcript language — questions that detect unworkable leads in the first 60 seconds:

Signal in transcript	Qualifying question	Decision rule
"Wir haben erst angefangen mit PV"	"Ab wie vielen PV-Aufträgen im Monat macht Software Sinn für Sie?"	< 5/month → DQ, 6-month callback
"Wir machen das mit Excel"	"Wie viele Stunden pro Woche verbringt Ihr Team mit Angeboten?"	< 6h/week → DQ

Signal in transcript	Qualifying question	Decision rule
"Ich bin nur der Lehrling / die Sekretärin"	"Wer trifft die Entscheidung für Software?"	Not DM → re-route immediately, don't pitch
"PlanCraft kostet weniger"	"Was zahlen Sie aktuell — alles inklusive?"	Get total cost before discussing HERO pricing

Why this goes beyond the obvious: The goal isn't to handle objections better — it's to surface them in the first 60 seconds and DQ faster. Shorter bad calls free up SDR capacity for good ones.

Task 3 — The Action Plan

Who to talk to first — and in what order

Day 1–3 — RevOps (first, always)

Validate before presenting to anyone. Key questions:

- Is `demos_completed` logged consistently across all SDRs?
- Is `dq_reason` a real CRM field, or are the 20 transcripts the only record?
- What feeds the lead score model — is trade or company size even a variable?

Don't share findings with Sales or Marketing until RevOps confirms the data is trustworthy.

Day 4–6 — Sales leadership

Frame as capacity unlock, not criticism:

"30% of SDR time goes to PV leads with a 40% connect rate. Here's how to protect your reps' time and focus them where they win."

Share: SDR effort chart + core-trade response-time finding. Agree on a 2h SLA for SHK/Elektro leads starting immediately.

Day 7–10 — Marketing

Frame as metric replacement, not blame:

"CPL is the wrong metric for us right now. Here's what Cost-per-Booking says about Meta Ads and PV campaigns."

Share: Source waterfall + PV trade-mix shift. Propose: gate PV leads at ≥ 6 employees + ≥ 5 jobs/month, and pause Meta Ads PV creative for 30 days as an experiment.

Week 2 — CRO + CEO

Two slides only:

1. The PV dilution math — trade mix chart + booking rate by trade. Arithmetic is undeniable.
2. The two fixes + projected impact — PV ICP gate and core-trade SLA.

Ask: approval to redefine PV MQL criteria and run a 30-day Meta pause as a controlled experiment.

How to measure success

Primary metric: Lead-to-Booking conversion rate

- Baseline: 10.1% overall; 6.4% in Q2 2026
- 4-week target: $\geq 12.0\%$
- 8-week target: $\geq 14.0\%$

Secondary metrics:

Fix	Metric	Baseline	4-Week Target	Owner
PV ICP gate	PV share of MQLs (≤ 5 MA)	~25% of pool	< 10%	Marketing
PV ICP gate	PV booking rate (filtered)	1.6%	> 5%	RevOps
Core-trade SLA	SHK/Elektro leads touched ≤ 2 h	~41%	> 80%	SDR Manager
Meta pause	Overall booking rate	10.1%	$\geq 12.0\%$	RevOps
DQ tagging	DQs with structured reason	~5%	> 80%	RevOps

Confirmation threshold: Booking rate $\geq 12\%$ after 4 weeks AND filtered PV leads booking at $\geq 5\%$ = H1 confirmed.

What if the hypothesis doesn't hold after 4 weeks?

If booking rate doesn't improve despite better PV filtering → H3 Implement pre-demo qualification gate: company size ≥ 6 employees, ≥ 5 jobs/month, decision-maker confirmed on call. Track demo-to-close weekly. Right metric: if demo-to-close rate improves but demo volume drops, qualification is tightening correctly.

If PV booking rate stays at 1.6% even with filtered leads → Product Transcripts surface the signal: PV installers expect PV-specific features (Auslegungssoftware, VDE protocols, PV proposal templates). This is a CPO conversation — pause *all* PV acquisition until the roadmap addresses it, but preserve the qualified-PV pipeline since those deals average €7,857.

If response-time SLA isn't moving → SDR tooling Audit timestamps in CRM by rep. If the bottleneck is routing speed, implement automated lead assignment with a 90-minute re-assignment rule if not touched.

Standing rule: Weekly metric review for 8 weeks. If leading indicators (connect rate and demo rate by trade) aren't moving by week 2, course-correct in week 3 — not week 4.

Data Caveats — Say These Proactively (1 min)

Three flags that show rigor, not weakness:

1. **The +38%/+9% baseline isn't in the data.** Q3 2025 is missing; Q2 2026 is April only. I can't reproduce those exact figures. Within the window I have, MQL growth is +61% QoQ and cohort conversion fell from 11.4% $\rightarrow$ 10.3% — same directional story, can't validate the headline numbers.

2. **Q2 2026 is a partial quarter.** The 6.4% booking rate is understated — April leads haven't finished converting. Treat it as a leading indicator, not a final result.
 3. **87.8% of leads have no outcome label.** 720 leads are neither booked nor in the DQ transcripts. The 10.1% booking rate assumes "no booking = lost." First RevOps conversation should clarify how many are still in active pipeline.
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Key Numbers to Remember

Metric	Number
Overall booking rate	10.1%
PV booking rate	1.6%
SHK booking rate	21.6%
PV share Q4 2025 → Q2 2026	34% → 58%
Avg PV deal size	€7,857 (highest of any trade)
Core-trade ≤2h booking rate	28.8%
Meta Ads booking rate	3.0%
Recoverable ARR from SLA fix	~€38k
Total booked revenue	€495,005